



The Giant's Causeway

An array of huge columnar rocks, famed worldwide for its spectacular geometric stepping-stone appearance

The Giant's Causeway is a group of thousands of interlocking columns of basalt rock at the foot of a cliff on the coast of Northern Ireland. The tops of the columns form a staircase that leads from the cliff foot up to a mound-shaped area, and then disappear under the sea.

Fiery origins

Legend has it that the Causeway was built by a giant, Fionn MacCoul, as a means of crossing the sea to fight a Scottish rival. It actually originated from lava poured out by volcanic fissures in the area roughly 55 million

years ago. The lava cooled and solidified to form thick layers of rock, some of which fractured into columns beneath the surface. After millions of years of erosion by glaciers, and later the sea, these structures were revealed at the surface.

Apart from the causeway itself, the surrounding area is excellent for studying sea birds and also for botanical studies, since some rare plants thrive here.



< FINE-GRAINED ROCK

The Giant's Causeway is composed of basalt, a dark rock that forms when a particular type of runny lava cools and solidifies rapidly.

Some of the **40,000 basalt columns** that form the causeway are more than **36 ft (11 m)** high



< Δ STEPPING-STONE COAST

These columns were once a mass of cooling lava, which solidified, shrank, and fractured to form geometric patterns similar to those sometimes seen in drying mud.

> ERODED CLIFFS

Behind the Giant's Causeway are cliffs eroded out of the plateau of northern Antrim. The basalt columns jut out of these cliff faces, forming jagged steps that creep into the sea.

